

37 Past possibility

You can use a variety of language to talk about possible events in the past, and to indicate whether you agree or disagree with speculation.

⚙️ **New language** “Might / may / could” in the past

Aa **Vocabulary** Urban myths

🧩 **New skill** Talking about past possibility

37.1 KEY LANGUAGE PAST POSSIBILITY

You can use this construction to talk about something that you think possibly happened in the past.



The copier isn't working. **It** { might
may
could } **have run** out of paper.

[He thinks it is possible that the copier has run out of paper.]

You can use this construction to talk about something that possibly did not happen in the past.



You { might not
may not } **have plugged** it in properly.

[He thinks it is possible that the printer wasn't plugged in properly.]

“Could not” can only be used when the speaker is certain that something did not happen.



You couldn't **have changed** the ink properly earlier.

[He is certain that the ink wasn't changed properly.]

